

# Prevention Improvements and Impacts on Children in Care

**Foster Insights**  
University of Chicago

2026

**FFPSA (2018) shifted  
the focus of child  
welfare policy  
towards prevention**

- Allowed Title IV-E to be used for in-home programming, including parenting services, substance abuse prevention, and mental health treatment
- Expanded eligible prevention services to also include those aimed at parents and kinship providers

## Nationwide data\* shows the marked change since FFPSA

| Year | Children in Foster Care | Entries into Foster Care |
|------|-------------------------|--------------------------|
| 2016 | 429,961                 | 273,174                  |
| 2017 | 436,552                 | 270,200                  |
| 2018 | 434,909                 | 262,902                  |
| 2019 | 426,566                 | 252,352                  |
| 2020 | 407,493                 | 216,838                  |
| 2021 | 391,641                 | 206,867                  |
| 2022 | 368,530                 | 186,602                  |
| 2023 | 340,069                 | 174,121                  |
| 2024 | 328,963                 | 170,955                  |

\* Source: AFCARS database: [https://tableau-public.acf.gov/views/afcars\\_dashboard\\_main\\_page/mainpage](https://tableau-public.acf.gov/views/afcars_dashboard_main_page/mainpage)

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**The total number of children in foster care has declined by nearly 25%...**

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**The total number of children in foster care has declined by nearly 25%...**

**...while new entries into foster care have decreased by over a third since FFPSA was enacted**

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## The shift towards prevention has also brought new challenges



### Re-Referrals

An increase in the number of children being re-referred to child welfare hotlines multiple times



### Child Needs

The population of children who *are* in foster care becoming more skewed towards those with high needs

## The shift towards prevention has also brought new challenges



### Re-Referrals

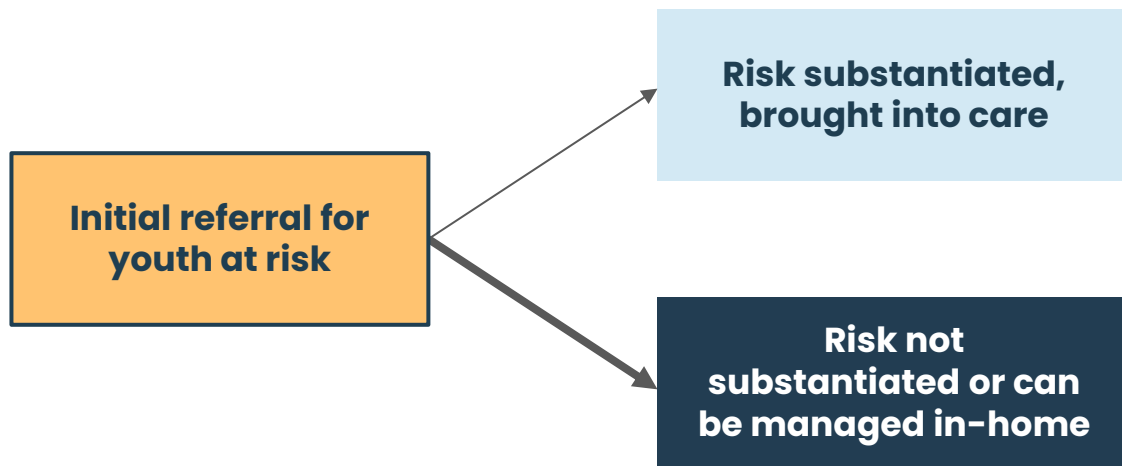
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### Child Needs

The population of children who *are* in foster care becoming more skewed towards those with high needs

**After referrals are made to CW hotlines, more cases are resulting in a youth *not* being brought into care**





**Ideally, many of those cases are then referred to service providers**



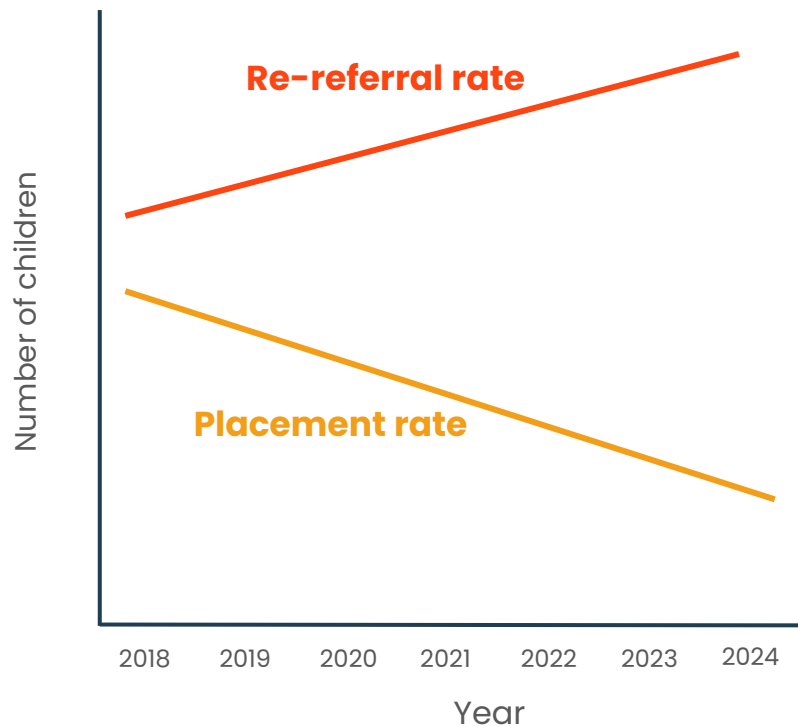
**However, connections to services are not always successful**



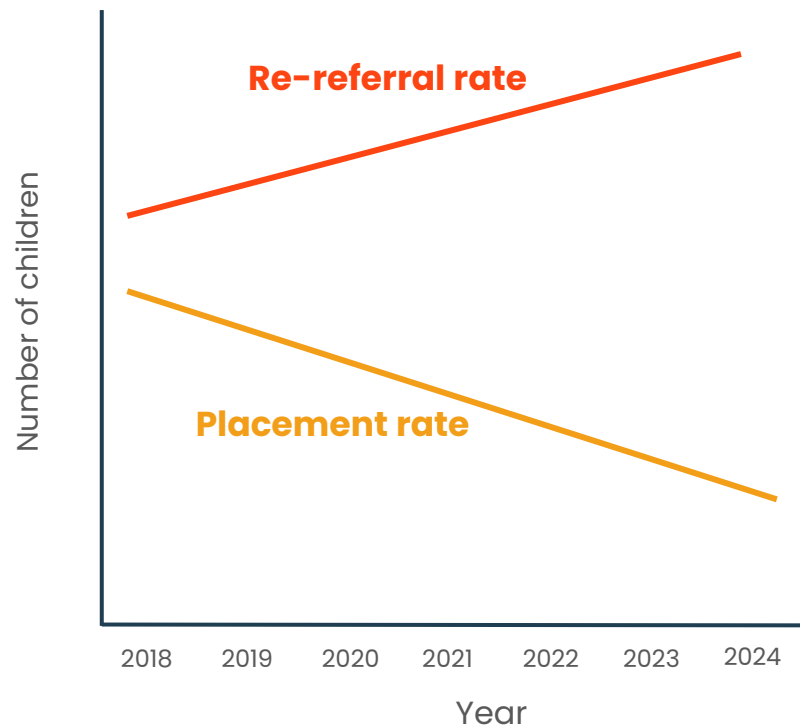
**Despite the positive of a child not coming into care, the underlying concern may not be addressed and lead to re-referrals**



**This pattern can lead to declining placement rates alongside increasing re-referral rates**



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Both placement rates  
AND re-referral rates  
declining would be a  
**signal of effective  
prevention on a  
holistic scale**

## Prevention Questions:

1. What have been particularly effective prevention measures in your jurisdiction?
  - a. What challenges do you continue to experience?
1. Have you experienced specific challenges related to service delivery?
  - a. E.g. lack of services in particular locations or low uptake from families
1. To what extent does your jurisdiction track re-referrals? How have re-referrals changed over the last 5 years?

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**We have observed a pattern of children in care having more complex behavioral and mental health needs over time**

**This may be due to a variety of factors, including:**

1. Greater focus on prevention efforts screening out less complex, lower needs cases
1. Increased focus from child welfare agencies on identifying child needs and reimbursing caregivers appropriately
1. Changing societal norms on awareness and diagnosis of mental health needs



# **The changing needs of children in care leads to a greater need for caregivers equipped to meet those needs**

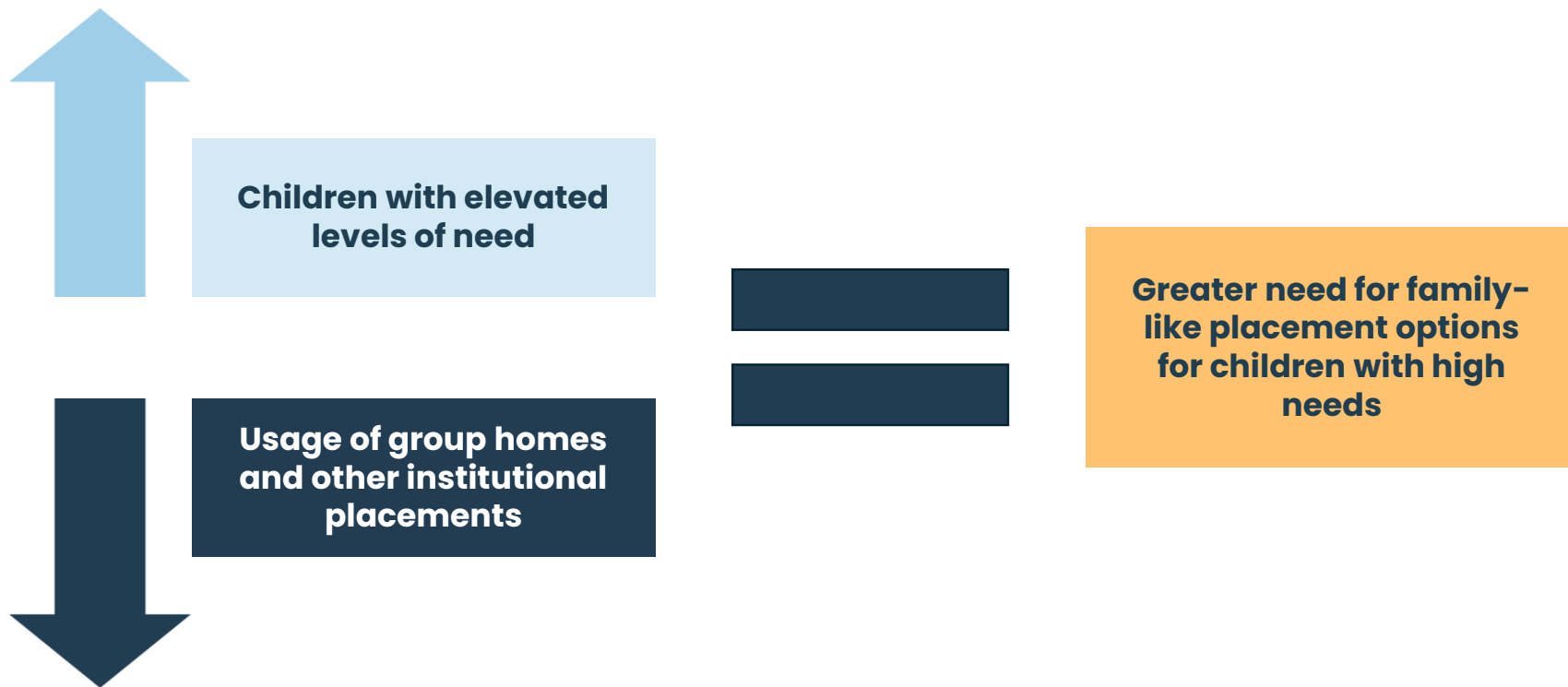


**Children with elevated  
levels of need**



**Usage of group homes  
and other institutional  
placements**

# The changing needs of children in care leads to a greater need for caregivers equipped to meet those needs



## **Leave reflections in the chat...**

**How have the needs of children in care changed in your jurisdiction?**

**What measures have been successful in providing suitable homes to meet those needs?**